Indian Ocean. Recent operations have extended to Indonesia, Sri Lanka, Yemen, Bangladesh, Myanmar, the Maldives, and East Africa. Finally, India has tried to lead regional institution-building at the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) and increase naval transparency and goodwill through the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS). In 2019, India also announced an Indo–Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) with seven pillars to facilitate international cooperation in a number of domains.

These initiatives, when taken together, are significant. But they still might not be enough. While India can certainly step up its own activities in the Indian Ocean, there are nonetheless limitations as to what it might be able to do, especially with respect to a country like Pakistan that also has an Indian Ocean coast. Thus, anticipating a larger Chinese naval presence, India should also be preparing for sea denial, and not just sea control. That will require much greater investments by the Indian Navy in its submarine fleet and in developing infrastructure on the Indian coast and its offshore islands (such as the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Lakshadweep). India does hold several natural advantages in the Indian Ocean, including geography and political goodwill. The Chinese navy will also face significant technical and logistic difficulties in operating in the Indian Ocean. [30] The prospect of greater Sino–Indian competition in the Indian Ocean should therefore lead to neither panic nor complacency on New Delhi's part. But further steps—including greater investments in the Indian Navy and smart allocations within the naval budget—may well be required.

Priority 6. Connect with Southeast Asia

Southeast Asia—the region home to the member countries of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)—will be the primary realm of geopolitical competition in Asia for the foreseeable future. Asia features several major resident powers—large countries with sizeable economies and militaries—including the United States, China, India, Japan, and Russia. By contrast, Southeast Asia has in recent decades seen dampened security competition and cooperation through ASEAN.